

# Conall Ring's American Revolution Notes

## Causes

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From the 1600s, Britain had established 13 colonies along the eastern seaboard of North America. The Colonists were from Britain and other European countries

- **The Enlightenment** emerged in Europe, and it challenged the idea that kings had a divine right to rule as they saw fit. They instead argued that power of government should be limited and the people's rights should be protected.
- The British Parliament had passed a series of **Navigation Acts**, which forced the colonies to sell some of their produce (cotton, sugar, tobacco) to Britain alone. This meant the British could decide the price, as the Americans had no one else to sell to.
- During the **Seven Years War**, huge numbers of British soldiers fought in America, and the British government wanted the colonies to contribute to the cost of the army.
- The British introduced the **Stamp Act (1765)** which required all legal documents, wills, newspapers, certificates and playing cards to have a government stamp—that had to be paid for—and the **Quartering Act (1765)** which imposed taxes to cover the cost of soldiers in the colonies. The people resented the taxes being forced upon them by a parliament in London in which they had no representatives, and opposition groups started using the slogan '**No Taxation without Representation.**' Groups such as the Sons of Liberty in Boston attacked British officials.

## The Lead-up to the War

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After they had repealed the Stamp Act, the British instead imposed the Townshend Acts in 1767, which placed taxes on goods that America imported, such as tea, glass, paint and lead.

- In 1770, a Boston mob, protesting the **Townshend Acts**, confronted a group of British soldiers. The soldiers opened fire and five people were killed in the '**Boston Massacre**'. Exaggerated accounts soon spread, claiming the soldiers used extreme violence against the civilians, leading to more public outrage. **The British removed all taxes except a small tax on tea imports** from the colonies soon after.
- In 1773, they passed the **Tea Act**, which exempted the East India Company from paying the tea tax, and in December 1773, a group from the Sons of Liberty dressed as Native Americans **dumped 342 crates of East India Company tea into the Boston Harbour**, an event later called the **Boston Tea Party**. The British responded by imposing the '**intolerable acts**' which closed the Boston Port until compensation was paid for the tea, the city was put under military rule, and the colony's assembly was suspended.
- The 'intolerable acts' worried the colonies, as they believed that the British could do the same to them, so **representatives of the colonies met in the First Continental Congress** in September 1774. The Congress **opposed all British taxes, and urged the colonies to boycott British goods**, and demanded the removal of British

soldiers. Secret groups began to stockpile weapons and militias started to train and arm themselves.

- The British **General Gage** attempted to stop these developments and in 1775, he sent 800 troops to **seize weapons at Concord**. An American Rebel, **Paul Revere**, heard about this and organised militiamen to ride throughout America and warn the rebels that **the British were coming**.
- At Lexington, a small group of American militiamen engaged the British troops, resulting in ten Americans being killed, and eight captured. **When the British reached Concord the weapons were gone**, and on their way back to Boston there was a larger battle, in which 273 British soldiers died.
- A pamphlet written by **Thomas Paine** called *Common Sense* was read widely throughout the colonies, and it argued that the British were suppressing the right of the American people, who should become independent in order to protect those rights.
- In **1776, the Second Continental Congress** met, and it chose **George Washington to be commander-in-chief** of the Continental Army. On 4 July 1776, the Congress issued the **Declaration of Independence** to separate the American colonies from British rule.

## The American War of Independence

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When George Washington was appointed commander-in-chief of the Continental Army in 1775, he faced a disheartening situation, as shown below.

| Continental Army                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | British Army                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>- 20,000 men</li><li>- Part-time soldiers, many serving for only short periods</li><li>- Poorly trained and equipped, many fought with farm tools.</li><li>- The soldiers were locals and had knowledge of the area, and could use this against the British.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>- 80,000 men</li><li>- Professional, full-time soldiers.</li><li>- Well-trained and equipped.</li><li>- Supplies from Navy</li><li>- Fighting in unfamiliar territory, no local knowledge</li><li>- Thousands of miles from home</li></ul> |

### Key Battles

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- Washington lost the battle at **Bunker Hill**, but inflicted heavy damage on the British.
- The Americans won the **Battle of Boston**, and captured cannons and rifles, giving them a better chance at winning the war.
- Washington was defeated at **New York** in 1776, but won in both **Princeton** and **Trenton**.
- In 1777, British **General Howe's** army of 18,000 men captured **Philadelphia**, home to the **Continental Congress**. This made people begin to doubt that America could win, and they questioned Washington's leadership.

- The month after the loss of Philadelphia, American General **Horatio Gates** defeated a British army of 8,000 men at Saratoga, this victory reassured the American people, and **France**, the **Netherlands** and **Spain** soon joined the war against the British.
- In 1778, France sent 6,000 troops and weapons to America, and disrupted the British supply lines with their fleet. Many British soldiers had to stay in Britain to defend if France decided to attack them also.
- After losing at Philadelphia, Washington regrouped at **Valley Forge** with 11,000 men during the winter of 1777. By the end of February 3,000 men had died from disease, hunger or from the cold and hundreds of troops also deserted. But by the end of winter, the army emerged from Valley Forge with undying loyalty to Washington after he refused to leave them even after the horrible conditions of the winter. During the Winter, the Prussian soldier **Baron Von Steuben** had drilled the soldiers until they were well trained and disciplined.
- Over the next few years, the Americans won more battles, and the British were mainly confined to **New York**. In **October 1781**, 7,000 British soldiers under Lord Cornwallis were surrounded by 9,000 American and 5,000 French troops on land and a French fleet at sea. Cornwallis surrendered to Washington, **ending the war**.
- The **Treaty of Paris** was signed between the colonies and the British in 1783.

## The Results of the Revolution

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- The 13 colonies became independent, but after the Treaty of Paris in 1783, conflicts arose between the colonies. In 1787, a **Constitutional Convention** led by Washington was called in order to create the **American Constitution**, which outlined the powers of the government and the rights of the citizens. The USA grew to 50 states over the next 200 years and by 1900 it was one of the most powerful countries in the world.
- The Revolution in America inspired similar revolutions in both France and Ireland. In France, bankrupted by the war, the rule of Louis XVI was starting to collapse. This paved the way for the **French Revolution in 1789**. In Ireland, we drew inspiration from the Americans and this led to the **1798 Rebellion**.
- The ideals of the American Revolution **inspired millions of black slaves, Indigenous Americans and women** to keep fighting for their rights over the next 200 years, and demanding their share of America's promise of liberty.